The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Police in Maryland said that the six people who remain missing after the **Francis Scott Key Bridge** across Baltimore Harbour collapsed are presumed dead. Search operations will resume on Wednesday after sunrise to recover their bodies. Wes Moore, the governor of Maryland, said *Dali*, a Singapore-flagged vessel, had suffered a power outage before crashing into the bridge. The accident could stop coal shipments from the port for several weeks.

Ceasefire talks between **Israel** and **Hamas** in Qatar appeared to hit an impasse after Israel recalled its negotiating team. A senior Israeli official blamed Hamas for sabotaging the discussions over a six-week truce in Gaza, according to Reuters. However Qatari and Egyptian officials, who are mediating the talks, believe that they could resume in the coming days.

Germany's leading economic research groups revised their growth forecasts for this year. They slashed their prediction for the country's GDP growth to 0.1%, down from a figure of 1.3% forecast six months ago. Germany was the world's worst-performing major economy last year, shrinking by 0.3% owing to weak domestic demand and an ailing export sector.

The lower chamber of **Thailand's** parliament passed a bill that paves the way for it to legalise same-sex marriage. The country would be the first in South-East Asia to do so. The bill must still pass through the country's upper chamber and receive royal assent. But it is widely expected to become law by the end of the year.

Xi Jinping, **China's** president, met several **American** business leaders in Beijing in an attempt to assuage their fears about investing in his country. Foreign direct investment into China

shrank in 2023 amid concerns over new regulations and government interference. Representatives from 20 firms met Mr Xi, including the bosses of Blackstone, a private-equity firm, and Qualcomm, a chips manufacturer.

Venezuela's opposition coalition managed to register a candidate for the presidential election scheduled for July. That outcome was uncertain, given that Nicolás Maduro's autocratic regime had blocked **María Corina Machado,** who won the opposition's primary, from signing up, as well as an alternative. The coalition registered a placeholder candidate, whom it can replace until April 20th.

Ukraine's football team qualified for **Euro 2024** by defeating Iceland in a play-off. The match took place in Poland where Ukraine have been playing all their home fixtures since Russia's invasion in 2022. Oleksandr Zinchenko, Ukraine's captain, dedicated the win to those "giving their lives for our freedom". The continental tournament will take place in Germany this summer.

Figure of the day: 45,000, the headcount at McKinsey, which has been growing faster than the consulting firm's revenues. Read the full story.

Photo: Reuters

Israel lashes out at America

An Israeli delegation was scheduled to visit the White House on Wednesday to resolve disagreements over the war in Gaza. But Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, told his envoys to stay home after America refused to veto a UN Security Council resolution that calls for an "immediate ceasefire" in Gaza. Mr Netanyahu called America's decision a "clear retreat" from its "consistent position"—a reaction that reflects his fear that it will undermine his already weak political standing at home.

Worsening hunger in Gaza is one of America's main concerns. The UN says that 1.1m people, half of the population, face "catastrophic" food shortages. Aid workers reckon that Gaza needs at least 300 lorry-loads of supplies each day, double the current number. Air drops cannot fill the gap, and deliveries by sea are still small. After months of American pleading, Israeli officials promised to "flood" the enclave with aid. Yet the flow remains only a trickle.

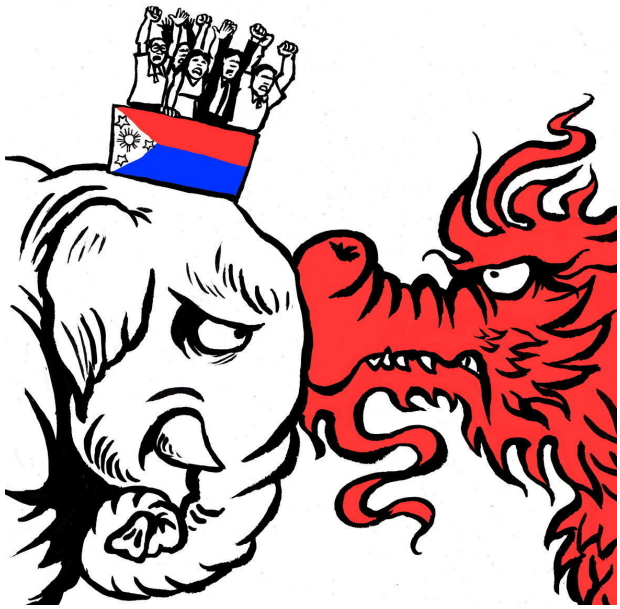


Photo: Dave Simonds

India and the Philippines resist China

India’s foreign minister, Subrahmanyam Jaishankar, completed a three-day visit to the Philippines on Wednesday. He spent his time in Manila, the capital, in talks aimed at strengthening Indo-Philippine co-operation to deter China. The countries’ partnership is part of a network that links Australia, India, Japan, the Philippines, the United States and Vietnam. All of these countries want to stop China from pushing its borders outwards into southern Asia and the western Pacific.

India and the Philippines are both having run-ins with China. Chinese forces clash with the Indian army in the Himalayas and with the Philippine navy in the South China Sea, almost all of which China claims as its own. India wants to help the Philippines counter the threat from China. It is soon expected to deliver “BrahMos” supersonic anti-ship missiles to the Philippines.

Photo: Rex Shutterstock

Argentines’ confidence in their economy

Argentina’s consumer-confidence index is published on Wednesday. President Javier Milei, a self-described “anarcho-capitalist”, will be hoping for a big rise. That would continue a string of economic successes from his first 100 days in office. The

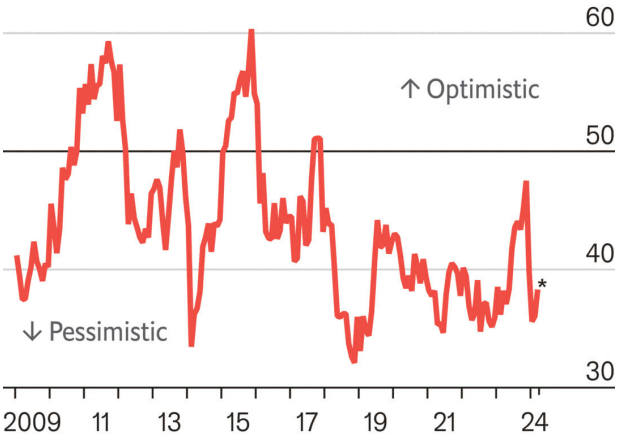
government has achieved monthly fiscal surpluses. Inflation, though extremely high at 13% a month, is falling.

The consumer-confidence survey asks about respondents' economic situation, their view of the country's and their expectations. It also asks whether now is a good moment to buy things such as cars and fridges.

After sharp plunges in the first two months of Mr Milei's presidency, Argentine consumers' confidence crept up in February. A bigger increase this month would suggest that the public have growing faith in his reforms, despite a deepening recession. Opposition parties, meanwhile, will pore over the numbers as they decide whether to back a package of tax reforms and deregulation that Mr Milei wants to push through Congress.

Turning a corner

Argentina, consumer confidence



*Forecast
Sources: Torcuato Di Tella University; Trading Economics

Photo: Getty Images

Desperate times for Myanmar’s army

Wednesday is Armed Forces Day in Myanmar. It’s an excuse for the army to hit the tarmac in Naypyidaw, the capital, awing the population with parades, tanks and fiery speeches. This year, however, the generals should be feeling less arrogant than at any time since February 2021, when they deposed the civilian government and provoked a civil war. Since October the army has suffered humiliating reversals against rebel militias in the north of the country. Thousands of troops, including six generals surrendered.

One sign of the army’s weakness—and desperation for more troops—is a conscription law that comes into effect in April. It stipulates that all men aged 18 to 35 and women aged 18 to 27 must serve at least two years. The draft is unpopular: thousands of Burmese have fled the country to avoid it. Officials attempting to identify eligible citizens have reportedly been killed. Most Burmese, it seems, do not wish to kill their countrymen or risk being killed by them.

Photo: PETER MOUNTAIN/NETFLIX

The Prince and the producer in “Scoop”

In November 2019 Emily Maitlis interviewed Prince Andrew for the BBC’s “Newsnight” about his friendship with Jeffrey Epstein, a convicted paedophile who had recently died. Andrew denied an accusation by one of Epstein’s victims that he had sex with her when she was 17. His arrogant defence of his association with Epstein was widely mocked.

Now the negotiations behind the interview have been turned into a film. “Scoop” has its world premiere in London on Wednesday. It streams on Netflix from April 5th. The cast includes Gillian Anderson (Ms Maitlis) and Rufus Sewell (Andrew). The drama is adapted from a memoir by Sam McAlister, a former “Newsnight” producer.

The same story is the subject of “A Very Royal Scandal”, a forthcoming three-part series by Amazon starring Ruth Wilson and Michael Sheen. Both will cater to the public’s curiosity about what goes on behind closed palace doors—and both will struggle to match the high drama of the interview itself.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Wednesday: What was the name of the first prequel in the Star Wars movie series, released in 1999?

Tuesday: What is the usual term for a provision in a bill that provides for a law to expire after a certain date?

> *For progressive people the present is the beginning of the future. For conservative people the present is the end of the past.*
>
> *Karl Mannheim*